SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #36 · LIFE-STAGE PRESSURES

# “Retirement means I'm no longer useful.”

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## Where it often comes from

For many people, work gave structure, status, and purpose. When it ends, whether by choice, health, or company decision, the days can feel empty and the world can seem to stop needing us. A culture that praises youth and productivity makes it worse, and so do family messages about “earning your keep.”

## What Scripture teaches

Scripture speaks warmly of the elderly. The psalmist says the righteous will flourish, and in old age they will still bear fruit. Proverbs calls gray hair a crown of glory. The psalmist prays, “Even when I am old and gray, do not forsake me, O God, until I proclaim Your power to the next generation.” God says, “Even to your old age, I will be the same, and I will bear you up when you turn gray.” Usefulness in God’s kingdom does not end with a career.

> *“In old age they will still bear fruit; healthy and green they will remain”* (Psalm 92:14).

## Also see

> “Even when I am old and gray, do not forsake me, O God, until I proclaim Your power to the next generation, Your might to all who are to come” (Psalm 71:18).

> “Gray hair is a crown of glory; it is attained along the path of righteousness” (Proverbs 16:31).

> “Even to your old age, I will be the same, and I will bear you up when you turn gray. I have made you, and I will carry you; I will sustain you and deliver you” (Isaiah 46:4).

> “The righteous will flourish like a palm tree, and grow like a cedar in Lebanon” (Psalm 92:12).

## Common self-statements

- Nobody needs me anymore.
- I have nothing left to give.
- My best years are behind me.
- I am just waiting around.
- I have no purpose without work.
- The world has moved on.

## Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either working and useful or retired and useless.
- Fortune telling: Predicting a meaningless future.
- Mental filter: Noticing the loss of role and missing the new opportunities.
- Labeling: Calling myself “retired” as if it were a verdict.

## Challenging questions

- What do I have to give that a lifetime of experience has made possible?
- Who could use my time, wisdom, or help?
- What did I always want to do but did not have time for?
- What does God say about fruitfulness in old age?

- What did work give me that I need to find elsewhere, such as structure, people, or purpose?
- What is one place I could serve this month?

## Truth summary

> My usefulness to God and others does not end with my career. I can still bear fruit, teach, serve, pray, and enjoy. This season may be one of the most meaningful, and I can look for how God wants to use me now.

## Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Elderly
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Servant
- Strength
- Fruitful

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Suffering

## Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

## Songs that speak truth to this belief

**Do It Again** — Steven Curtis Chapman
God's repeated gifts and new mercies express His continuing love.

**Forever** — Kari Jobe
Christ's resurrection grounds hope in His victory over sin and death.

**Great Is Thy Faithfulness** — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

**How Great Thou Art** — Jordan Smith
This classic hymn connects God's greatness, Christ's sacrifice, and future hope.

*Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"*

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# My Plan for Replacing "Retirement means I'm no longer useful"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

## 1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

*Rate it now so you can see your progress later.*

"Retirement means I'm no longer useful." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

## 2 My best question

*The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.*

- ☐ What can I offer?
- ☐ Who needs my help?
- ☐ What did I always want to do?
- ☐ What does God say about old age?
- ☐ What did work give me that I need to replace?
- ☐ Where could I serve this month?

My own question: _____

## 3 My replacement truth

*The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.*

- ☐ I can still bear fruit.
- ☐ Gray hair is a crown of glory.
- ☐ God will carry me.
- ☐ My experience is valuable.
- ☐ Purpose does not require a paycheck.
- ☐ This season has its own calling.

In my own words: _____

## 4 My Scripture

*The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.*

- ☐ **Psalm 92:14**
  *"In old age they will still bear fruit; healthy and green they will remain."*
- ☐ **Psalm 71:18**
  *"Even when I am old and gray, do not forsake me, O God, until I proclaim Your power to the next generation, Your might to all who are to come."*
- ☐ **Isaiah 46:4**
  *"Even to your old age, I will be the same, and I will bear you up when you turn gray. I have made you, and I will carry you; I will sustain you and deliver you."*

A verse I found myself: _____

# Practicing the Truth

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## 5 My practice plan

*Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.*

### EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

### PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ How I helped: Each week, write one way you were useful to someone, in a small way or large.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  *For example, Psalm 92:14 becomes: "Sarah can write: "In old age I can still bear fruit, so I am still useful to God.""*
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Elderly" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

## 6 My action step this week

*Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.*

*This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.*

- ☐ List what you can offer. Write skills, stories, and gifts that others could use.
- ☐ Find one place to serve. Contact a church, school, nonprofit, or neighbor and offer your time.
- ☐ Build a routine. Create a simple daily rhythm with prayer, activity, and people.
- ☐ Mentor someone. Offer to share what you know with a younger person.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

## 7 End-of-week check-in

*Bring this page to your next session.*

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Retirement means I'm no longer useful": _____ %  My truth: _____ %

## Daily practice tracker

| Day | Read my card | Said my verse | Used my reminder | A way I served |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | | | | |
| Tue | | | | |
| Wed | | | | |
| Thu | | | | |
| Fri | | | | |
| Sat | | | | |
| Sun | | | | |

## My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

| Day | Song I listened to | What it told me that challenges the lie |
|---|---|---|
| Mon | | |
| Tue | | |
| Wed | | |
| Thu | | |
| Fri | | |
| Sat | | |
| Sun | | |

## My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Retirement means I'm no longer useful.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

*Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.*

## Prayer

*Lord, You said we will still bear fruit in old age. Show me where You want to use me in this season, and free me from the belief that I am no longer needed. Amen.*

*Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.*